Original thinkers include ***Somananda*** (900–50 CE), ***Utpaladeva*** (925–75 CE) and ***Abhinavagupta*** (975–1025 CE) who teach a form of absolute idealism according to which everything that appears to us as material and everything individual is projected by a single consciousness. The argument is that whatever causes the physical world must be non-physical. Since individual centres of consciousness are localised by matter, the ultimate source must be unconditioned, creative universal consciousness. On the individual level, we can only make sense of the coherence of our experiences and memories if they belong to a single persisting conscious subject (inhabiting a stable world regulated by objective structures). This is extended macrocosmically. The universe of subjects and objects holds together because it has a single conscious source that preserves it in being. The coordination of diverse subjects and objects is possible only if they are aspects of a single, universal field of experience. Universal Consciousness causes objects of awareness to appear as if distinct from the limited subjects of experience. The forms figuring in our awareness have as their objects the ideas (*abhasa*) projected by the universal consciousness.

The goal of religious practice is the transcendence of limited individual subjectivity. Enlightenment is the realisation that the subject that has selfishly considered itself as an individual is identical with the universal transcendental conscious energy (*samvit*), named *Shiva*. Liberation from rebirth (***moksha***) is the recognition that, 'I am Shiva and this whole world is my self-expression'. The authentic identity is already present as the constant background to all experience but must be re-cognised and reflected upon as the ultimate conscious principle manifesting itself as all limited subjects, acts and objects of experience. What appear as external, physical objects depend upon consciousness. Since causality is exclusively a property of conscious agents capable of volition, creativity by the